FREE CARDS

Feelings in My Body

Interoception cards that link what happens in your body to what you feel, including worry, anger, excitement, crushes and calm.

WHO IT IS FOR
Autistic children, young people and adults, with the parents, carers, teachers, SNAs and therapists who support them.

NCCA STAGE
Primary · Junior Cycle · Senior Cycle and LCA · Adults

Easy read

My body gives me signals. Signals tell me how I feel. I can learn to notice them. I can look after myself.

How to use this resource

- Print and cut out the cards. Laminate them if you can. Use two or three cards at a time.
- Pause often and ask: 'What is my body telling me?' Then match the signal to a card.
- There are no right or wrong answers. Bodies feel feelings in different ways, and some people notice very little. That is OK.
- Fill in the calm-down plan when you are calm, not in the middle of a hard moment.

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Version 1.0 · feelings-in-my-body

What is interoception?

Interoception is the sense that tells you what is happening inside your body. It tells you if you are hungry, thirsty, tired, hot, need the toilet, or have a feeling. Feelings have body signals. A fast heartbeat, a tight tummy or warm cheeks can be signals. Some autistic people notice these signals a lot. Some notice them very little. Some notice them late. Interoception can be practised.



My body gives me signals.



I stop. I notice. I name it.



All feelings are OK. Some are hard.

My feelings scale

How big is my feeling?



1. Calm

Body is slow and relaxed.



2. A little bit

I notice a small feeling.



3. Getting bigger

My body feels tight or fast.



4. Very big

I need help to calm down.



5. Too much

I need to go to my safe place.

Notes for adults

- Interoception is the sense of the internal state of the body. Differences in interoception are common in autistic people. A young person may not feel hunger, thirst, pain or the need to use the toilet until late, or may find signals very strong.
- Do not tell a person how they feel. Offer choices: 'Is your tummy tight, or is your heart fast?' Use the cards to build words. Notice together and without pressure.
- Name the body signal, then the feeling, then a helpful action. Practise when calm, not mid-crisis.
- A person who is very upset cannot learn. Wait until the moment has passed.

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Body signal cards: set 1

Cut out the cards. For each card, ask: 'Do I feel this? When?' Some feelings have more than one signal.



Happy

Body feels light. I smile. I want to move. I feel warm inside.

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Calm

My breathing is slow. My shoulders are down. My body feels still.

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Worried

My tummy feels tight. My head is full of 'what if'. I want to check things.

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Nervous

My hands are sweaty or shaky. My heart beats fast. My tummy flutters.

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Excited

My heart beats fast. I feel full of energy. I want to jump or talk fast.

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Angry

My face is hot. My fists are tight. My jaw is tight. I want to shout.

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Body signal cards: set 2



Sad

My chest feels heavy. I may cry. I feel tired or slow. I want to be alone or have a hug.

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Unwell

My tummy hurts. My head aches. I feel hot, cold or dizzy. I tell an adult.

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A crush

My heart beats fast. My cheeks feel warm. My tummy flutters. I think about the person a lot.

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Attraction

I feel drawn to someone. I may feel warm, shy or excited. These feelings are normal and private.

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Embarrassed

My face goes red and hot. I want to hide. My tummy feels odd.

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Tired

My eyes feel heavy. My body feels slow. I need to rest or sleep.

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Body signal cards: set 3 (what helps)

When a feeling is big, one small action can help. Try each one when you are calm, so you know what works for you.



Breathe

Breathe in for 4. Breathe out for 6. Do it five times.

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Drink water

Take small sips of cold water.

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Go to a quiet place

Go to my safe place. Ask for a break.

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Squeeze or press

Press my hands together. Squeeze a ball. Ask for a firm hug.

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Tell someone

'I feel ___ in my ___. I need ___.'

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Move

Walk, stretch or shake it out. Go outside if you can.

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Crushes and big feelings about people

Many people have a crush at some time. A crush is a strong, happy and sometimes nervous feeling about a person. Crushes can be about someone of any gender. Some people never have crushes. Both are normal.



A crush is a feeling. It is OK to have it.



A crush is private. I can tell a person I trust.



The other person does not have to feel the same.



I do not touch, follow or keep messaging a person.

You notice your heart beating fast near your crush



My heart is fast. It is a crush feeling. That is OK.

You are not sure what the feeling is



I have a big feeling in my tummy. Can you help me work out what it is?

You feel very nervous or worried



I feel worried in my tummy. I am going to take a break.

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My calm-down plan

Fill this in with a trusted person, when you are calm. Keep a copy at home and at school or work.

My body signals

When I am getting upset, my body feels: _____

The first signal I notice is: _____

A feeling that is hard for me is: _____

What helps me

Three things that help me to calm down: _____

My safe place is: _____

Something that does not help: _____

Who can help

A person who helps me: _____

What I will say or show to ask for help: _____

What I do when I feel calm again: _____

Notes for adults

- Co-regulation comes before self-regulation: stay calm, speak little and slowly, and keep the environment quiet. Do not ask 'why' during a meltdown.
- Agree a signal, such as a card, a gesture or a word, that the young person can use to ask for a break without having to speak.
- Check the basics: hunger, thirst, tiredness, toilet needs, noise, light and temperature. Many big feelings start with a body need.
- Do not link calm with reward or punishment. Calm is not a behaviour to be earned.
- If feelings are very big or last a long time, talk to the GP. Young people can phone Childline (1800 66 66 66), and anyone can text HELLO to 50808.

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Curriculum links

NCCA and Department of Education alignment

- Primary SPHE (1999), strand **Myself**, strand units *Taking care of my body* and *Growing and changing*: recognising and managing feelings.
- Junior Cycle SPHE (2023), Strand 4 *Emotional Wellbeing* and Strand 1 *Understanding Myself and Others*: emotions, stress and ways of coping.
- Senior Cycle SPHE: new specification published 2024, being introduced for fifth years, includes emotional wellbeing. Leaving Certificate Applied: Social Education.
- Department of Education Wellbeing Policy Statement and Framework for Practice (2018, updated 2019); NCCA guidance on RSE for students with special educational needs.

Universal Design for Learning

Every Autism & Me resource offers more than one way in: pictures and words together, an easy-read line, things to do with your hands, and scripts to practise. Keep the learning aim the same for everyone, and change the route. No diagnosis is needed to use any support in this resource.

Getting support in Ireland

Text About It

Free text support any time: text HELLO to 50808.

Childline (ISPCC)

Free, 24 hours: phone 1800 66 66 66, text 50101, or chat at childline.ie. For anyone under 18.

Parentline

Support for parents and carers: 01 873 3500, parentline.ie.

Your GP or public health nurse

For questions about puberty, periods, body changes or health checks.

Your school

Talk to the Designated Liaison Person (DLP) for child safeguarding, a class tutor or year head.

Autism & Me

Questions about this resource or training for your school: contactautismandme@gmail.com · autismandme.ie

If a child tells you something worrying

Stay calm. Listen, and believe them. Do not promise to keep it a secret. Write down what they said in their own words, with the date. Pass it on the same day: in a school, to the Designated Liaison Person (DLP); otherwise to Tusla. If anyone is in immediate danger, call 112 or 999. Follow *Children First: National Guidance for the Protection and Welfare of Children* (2017).

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